I lobbied harder for a medical cover for the team and, by the second year, we got one. The clearance, however, was cumbersome in parts and arbitrary on the whole. A medical practitioner was appointed in the community to certify prescriptions and treatments. For routine purchases of medicines, however, this was helpful, though not all medicines were reimbursed.

On one of my visits to the Indian Embassy in Paris, I saw Sondhi, an administrative officer. He was sitting with a list of medical claims, with two pens in hand. The officer ticked some names on the prescription red and some others green. Green meant approved, red rejected. I asked Sondhi if there was a criterion followed for denying some claims.

'Yes,' replied Sondhi matter-of-factly. 'The government has clearly listed out medicines and services which can be reimbursed.'

He did not have a medical background, and hence I was impressed by the pace at which he marked the prescriptions with red and green. I was wrong. Soon I found that Sondhi had rejected and approved the same medication on different occasions. I confronted him.

'Why do you make an issue out of this, Mr Nambi,' he said. 'This is something all offices do. When the auditor goes through the claims he would look for a few rejections. He will be happy with the meticulous work I had done.'

There was no point arguing with this man. I left.

While the two major medical needs tested my patience with the bureaucracy, what turned out to be a litmus test for my nerves was guarding the secret of the death of a scientist's son. S Balakrishnan, a brilliant mechanical engineer was among the short-term recruits we brought from ISRO to work in SEP to generally give them a little exposure. At any point there would be not more than three such scientists, and they would return to India after three months at Vernon. We had an apartment for them, or some of them shared the place with bachelor colleagues.

Balakrishnan was to work in the programme coordination group headed by A Sampath. It was March 1975. Within a week of his arrival, I got a call from his father D P Subbaiah. Balakrishnan's one-and-a-half-year-old son